

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

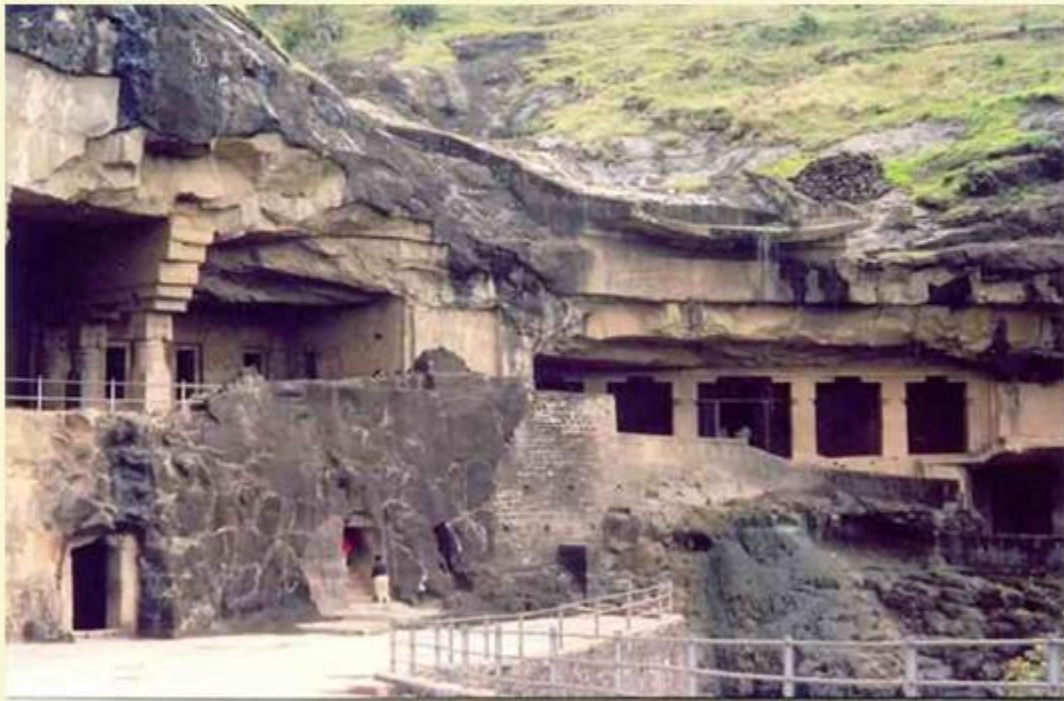
MODULE - 15

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

▪ **AJANTA CAVES**

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

WHAT DO YOU MEAN BY IT?



- 1 Rock-cut architecture refers to creation of structures (objects of art) by cutting and removal of stones from solid natural rock, till what is left is the structure intended to be created.
- 2 This style of architecture has been an important form of **religious artistic expression** in India for centuries.
- 3 Over 1500 known rock-cut structures survive even today, **the oldest being the Barabar caves of Mauryan period.**
- 4 In the post Mauryan period hundreds of such caves were excavated.

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WHAT DO YOU MEAN BY IT?



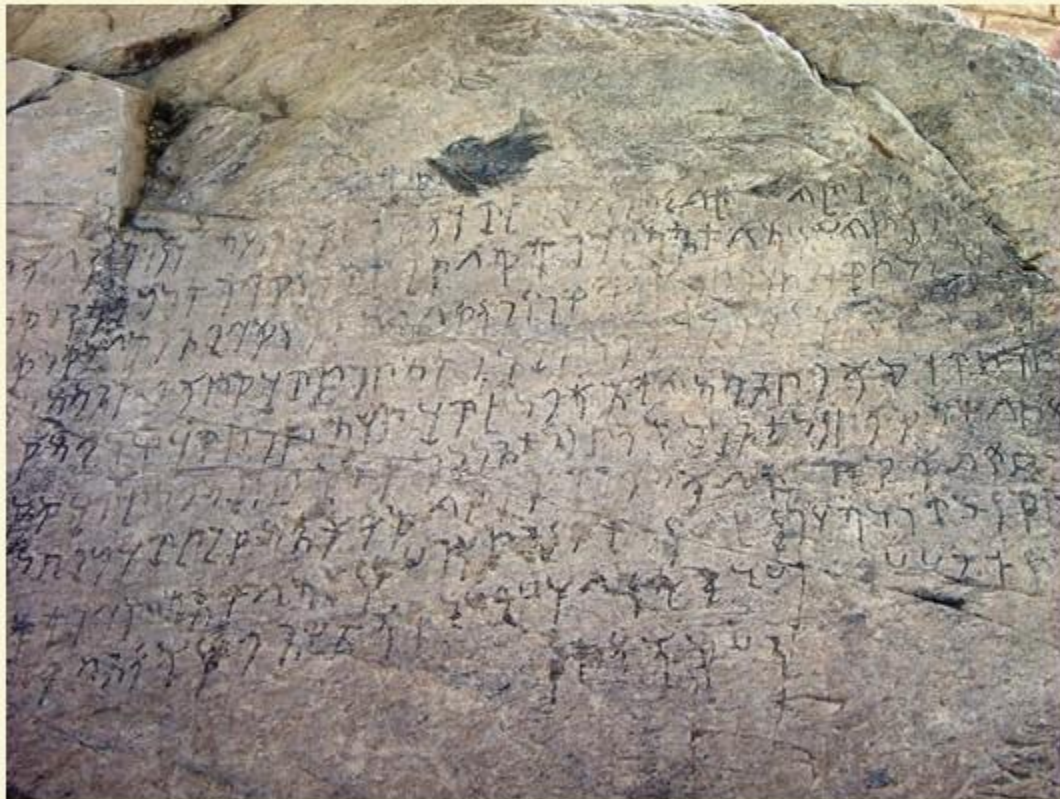
5 Before the advent of Buddha (6th century B.C.) the perishable and less durable materials such as wood, bamboo, brick, reed, cloth and clay were used.

6 As per the Hindu traditions, wood was considered as the best suited medium for making sacred objects.

7 Also, the wood was easy to transform in any shape; for instance bamboo could be easily bent to obtain curvature, etc.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

THE HUMBLE BEGINNINGS....



- 1 The beginning of earlier rock-cut cave architecture goes back to the Mauryan period.
- 2 During the Mauryan rule the stone was used as medium for column and statues.
- 3 The Mauryan emperor Ashoka (268 BCE-232 BCE) used stone as a medium of proclamation for the message of law and tolerance known as “Dhamma” through the rock edicts and pillar edicts.
- 4 The rock edicts were carved on the living rock which later became as a source of encouragement for the architectural activities in the rock.

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THE HUMBLE BEGINNINGS....



BARABAR CAVES

5 In the oldest Barabar caves there are seven rock-cut chambers- four on Barabar hills and three on Nagarjuni hills in Bihar (Gaya).

6 Archaeologically, these chambers are important as they are the earliest example of rock-cut technique copied from wood and thatch architecture.

7 On the Barabar hills, Sudama and Lomas rishi caves are most significant example.

8 The doorways of both these chambers have been carved in the fashion of wooden arch.

ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

WHY CAVES IN WESTERN GHATS?



1 The Western Ghats became the centre of rock-cut activities **as these were the ancient trade routes and traders were the potential patrons of such works.**

2 As a result of this, more than a thousand excavations came into being. Among these most famous are: Bhaja, Nasik, Junnar, Bedsa, Karle, Kanheri, Kondane, Pitalkhora, Aurangabad, Ellora and Ajanta.

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WHY CAVES IN WESTERN GHATS?

3 They were invariably religious in nature and a large number of them were of Buddhist origin.

4 The Ajanta, Ellora, Bhaja, Kanaheri, Karla, Elephanta, Nashik, Pitalkhora, Junaar, Badami, Udayagiri, and Khandagiri are amongst the most famous of rock-cut caves.

5 Amongst these **Junnar has the maximum number of caves** (more than two hundred).

6 The subjects of the rock-cut structures varied, from simple chaitya, viharas, and temples to beautiful sculptures and paintings.

7 Existence of mural paintings is another speciality with regard to Ajanta caves.

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AJANTA CAVES



- 1 The Ajanta, a UNESCO World heritage site near Aurangabad (Maharashtra) is among the most famous and the most exquisite example of art of ancient of India, especially of painting.
- 2 The caves were discovered in 1819 (by a British hunting expedition).
- 3 They are excavated in a horseshoe bend of rock surface overlooking a stream.
- 4 Ajanta (near Aurangabad, Maharashtra) has 29 entirely Buddhist caves.
- 5 Out of these, five are chaityas while the rest are viharas.

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6

These caves were built from 2nd century BCE to 6th century CE in two phases- the first phase beginning from 2nd century BCE while the second phase was from 400 to 650 CE.

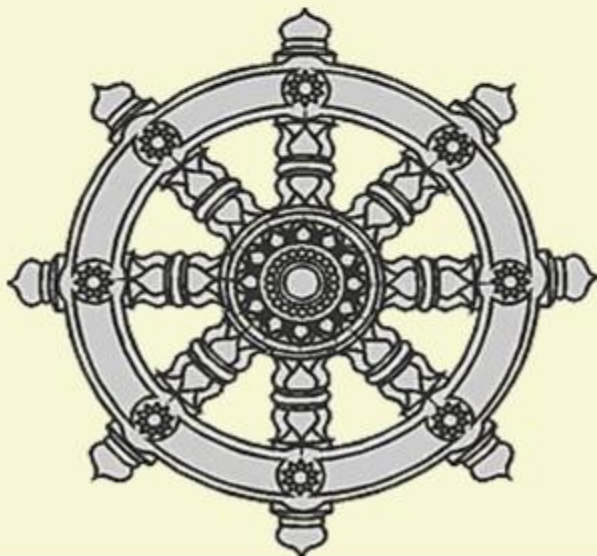
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The subject of excavation in all the caves are Buddhist. The earlier caves belong to the Hinayana phase while the latter to Mahayana.

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AJANTA CAVES



8

The phase division can also be explained in another way. The Ajanta caves can be divided into 2 phases i.e. Satavahana phase and Vakataka Phase.

9

In the first phase, Chaityas and Viharas were carved out in the second century BC, under the patronage of **Satavahana Kings** and this phase, is often known as the **Hinayana phase**, as a symbolic representation of Buddha was done.

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AJANTA CAVES



10 In this phase more, the focus was given on stupa and figurative sculpture was neglected.

11 The construction under the second phase was done during Gupta and Post Gupta periods (in 5th and 6th century AD) under the rule of the Vaktaka Kings.

12 Since in this phase Buddha was depicted as a human thus it was also known as Mahayana Phase.

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13

Several dynasties and patrons are known to have contributed to the Ajanta caves. These include the Vakatakas who were contemporary of Guptas. **Varahdeva, minister of Vakataka King Harisena, was patron of cave no. 16.**

14

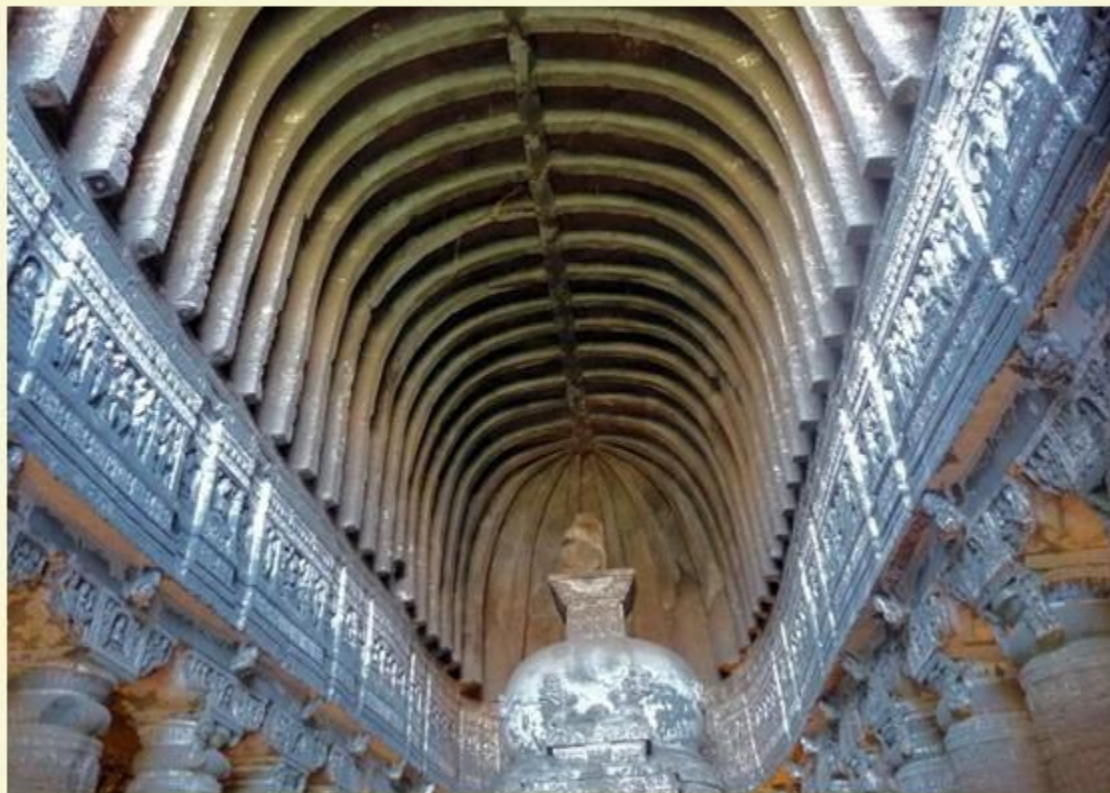
Among the other important patrons at Ajanta were **Upendragupta** (patron of Cave Nos. 17–20) the local king of the region and feudatory of the Vakataka king, Harishena; **Buddhabhadra** (patron of Cave No. 26); and **Mathuradasa** (patron of Cave No. 4).

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AJANTA CAVES

SCULPTURES OF AJANTA



APSIDAL VAULT-ROOF IN AJANTA

1

The chaitya Cave Nos. 19 and 26 are elaborately carved. Their facade is decorated with Buddha and, Bodhisattva images.

2

They are of the apsidal-vault-roof variety.

3

Images of Buddha, Bodhisattvas, and scenes from Jatakas and Avadanas are included in the sculptures and paintings.

4

The chaitya caves 19 and 26 contain elaborate carvings with the biggest image being that of Buddha's Mahaparinibbana (cave no. 26).

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AJANTA CAVES

SCULPTURES OF AJANTA



MAHAPARINIBBANA SCULPTURE IN CAVE 26

5

Cave No. 26 is very big and the entire interior hall is carved with a variety of Buddha images, the biggest one being the Mahaparinibbana image.

6

The rest of the caves are vihara-chaitya caves. They consist of a pillared veranda, a pillared hall and cells along the walls.

7

The back wall has the main Buddha shrine. Shrine images at Ajanta are grand in size.

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PAINTINGS OF AJANTA



**PAINTED CEILING,
CAVE NO. 10, AJANTA**

1

The caves include both paintings as well as rock-cut sculptures.

2

The mural paintings, in particular, are extremely expressive and depict various emotions through forms, poses and gestures. They are based on Jataka tales narrating the lives of Buddha.

3

Mural paintings of Ajanta use fresco technique. In fresco technique, the surface wall is coated with a thin layer of lime plaster on which the paintings are drawn with watercolour when the surface is still wet.

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PAINTINGS OF AJANTA

WHAT IS FRESCO METHOD?

The paintings were done using the fresco method. It involves a 3-step technique:

- A layer of clay, mixed with cow dung and rice husk was applied on the surface of the rock.
- A coating of lime plaster was then applied on the top of it.
- Colours and pigment were then applied on the moist surface.
- This allowed pigment to seep in and create a lasting image on the rock surface.
- Example: dying princess, flying apsara.

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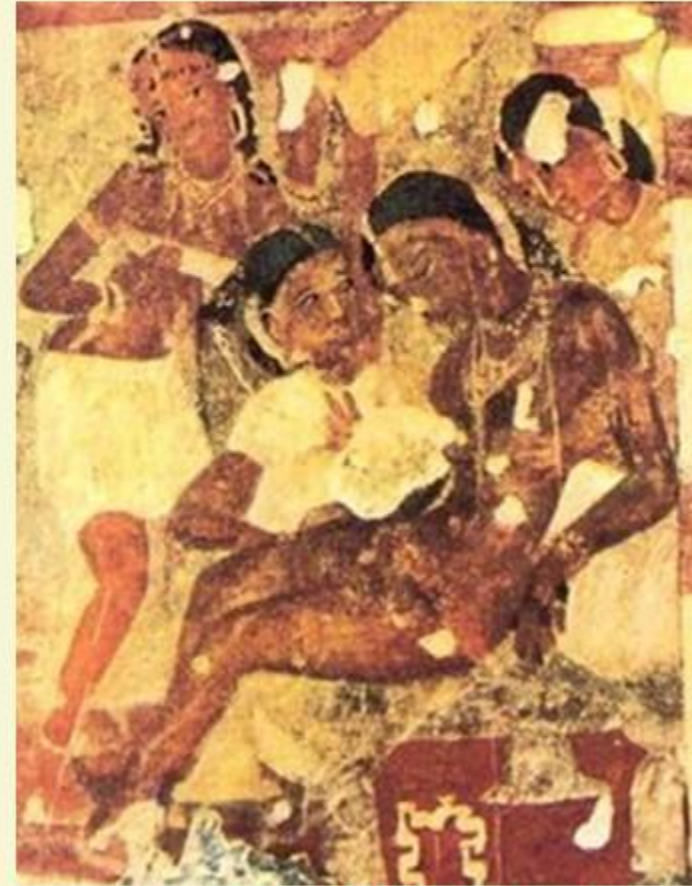
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PAINTINGS OF AJANTA



FLYING APSARA



DYING PRINCESS

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PAINTINGS OF AJANTA- EARLY PHASE



1 Here the colours used were limited as there was no over-stylisation of images.

2 The lines of the paintings are clearly defined with body of colours merging with outline creating a volume effect.

3 Figures in these caves are painted with considerable naturalism and there is no over-stylisation.

4 Events are grouped together according to geographical location.

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AJANTA CAVES

PAINTINGS OF AJANTA- LATER PHASE

1

The next stage of development is observed mainly in the paintings of Cave Nos. 16, 17, 1, & 2.



**Painting depicting Buddha,
Yashodara and Rahul**

2

Colours with natural tones have been used like brown, yellowish brown, yellow ochre, and greenish.

3

The outlines of the paintings were done in dark brown/red colour and then the inside was painted.

4

The colours were obtained from local vegetation and minerals.

5

The different skin colours represent multi-coloured population. The most famous painting is the one of the Buddha with Rahul and Yashoda.

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AJANTA CAVES

PAINTINGS OF AJANTA- EARLY PHASE



**THE FAMOUS PADMAPANI
MURAL OF AJANTA**

6

The painting of Bodhisattva Padmapani from cave 1 is a renowned masterpiece.

7

The paintings of Cave Nos. 1 and 2 are very orderly and naturalistic, well integrated with the sculptures in the caves.

8

In 1983 Ajanta cave was declared as the UNESCO World Heritage Site and according to UNESCO, these caves are masterpieces of Buddhist religious art and further influenced Indian art that followed.

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